

Travis Bickle's transformation

Before

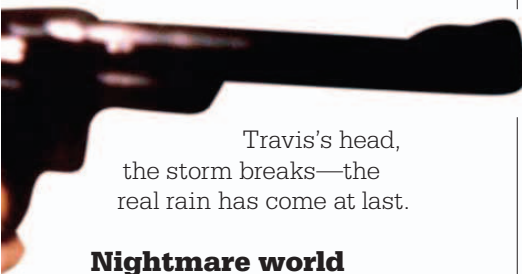
- Is mentally unstable, drinks heavily, and suffers from insomnia
- An ex-marine, struggles to fit in and connect with other people
- Wears a casual checked shirt, jeans, and shoes
- Keeps a diary
- Visits porn theaters regularly



After

- Shaves his hair into a threatening mohawk, and wears sunglasses to hide his eyes
- Becomes ever more mentally unstable and violent, developing an obsessive delusion that assassinating Senator Palatine will make him a hero
- Wears an army combat jacket and a badge bearing the presidential slogan, to help him blend into the crowd during his assassination attempt
- Conceals guns and a knife under his clothing

gear, shaves his head into a mohawk, and sets out to enact vengeance on Iris's pimp, Sport (Harvey Keitel), in what turns out to be a horrific bloodbath. Inside



Travis's head, the storm breaks—the real rain has come at last.

Nightmare world

The cinematography of Travis's rampage is hallucinogenic in its contrasting colors and unnerving angles, as though the movie is now descending fully into unreality. Like the opening shot of the steam,

with the cab emerging through it, and Travis's mumbled narration, the climax of the movie appears to take place in a nightmare world. Scorsese has often talked about movies existing at the intersection of dreams and reality, and this is where he takes the audience.

A dreamy coda to the slaughter, in which Travis survives and becomes a tabloid hero, has been interpreted as his dying fantasy. Whether real or imagined, it is Travis's longed-for moment in the spotlight. Writer Paul Schrader sees the end as taking the audience back to the beginning, and so Travis drives away, but neither he nor the world has been cured. ■

“Are you **talkin' to me?**
Well, I'm the **only one here.**”

Travis Bickle / Taxi Driver



Robert De Niro Actor

Robert De Niro has starred in more than 90 movies, eight of them directed by Martin Scorsese. He rose to fame playing the young Vito Corleone in Francis Ford Coppola's *The Godfather: Part II*, and soon won a reputation for his dedicated approach to researching his roles. His preparation for Scorsese's *Raging Bull* became legendary after he gained 60lb (27kg) to play the boxer Jake LaMotta.

For the first three decades of his career, De Niro specialized in the portrayal of misfits, outsiders, and violent, unpredictable personalities, from Corleone and Travis Bickle to Al Capone in Brian De Palma's *The Untouchables* (1987) and Max Cady, the stalker in Scorsese's *Cape Fear* (1991). More recently he has played gentler, less volcanic roles, and diversified into comedy.

Key movies

1973 *Mean Streets*
1974 *The Godfather: Part II*
1976 *Taxi Driver*
1978 *The Deer Hunter*
1980 *Raging Bull*